

Formidable partnership: From high-school sweethearts to marriage, Sreejesh and his wife Aneeshya's relationship progressed as smoothly as the former's rise through the ranks of Indian hockey. THULASI KAKKAT

spanned the 2011 rule change, which replaced penalty strokes with the current one-on-one format. Sreejesh believes the new system has levelled the playing field for goalkeepers.

"From a keeper's perspective, a penalty stroke is 90% a goal and 10% a save. The ball is just seven yards away, and the flick is usually accurate and powerful.

"But the current shootout format makes it almost 50-50 and fairer to us. The goalkeepers have an equal chance to make a save. The striker has multiple shots, but only eight seconds, and that's their biggest disadvantage," Sreejesh explained, briefly drowned out by the hum of crickets.

The post-Sreejesh era for Indian hockey began auspiciously, with Krishan Pathak stepping into the goalkeeper role during the team's recent Asian Champions Trophy win. This smooth transition was partly thanks to Sreejesh, who had shared minutes with Pathak, including during India's 2023 Asian Champions Trophy win. As Pathak recounted in an interview with this publication, Sreejesh also mentored him over the years, especially during the 2016 Junior World Cup.

However, Sreejesh downplayed his role, highlighting his own motivations in guiding the next generation of goalkeepers.

"I have a mentality — what I taught him [Pathak] felt like I was learning it twice. Sharing what we know allows us to learn it better too. More than being a service to others, it's something I did for myself. I learn more, and it benefits me. It's a selfish mentality, to be honest. Anything I did so far was 1) for the love of the game, 2) the love of the position, and 3) my own improvement," Sreejesh admitted.

Cramped legs and exhausted photo angles led to a location



change, prompting Sreejesh to invite us inside, guiding us through his vast collection of accolades with the skill of a seasoned museum guide. Anyone expecting a special, reverential spot for Sreejesh's Olympic medals would be surprised by their location.

A rummage through cluttered showcases might uncover a Khel Ratna, an Arjuna Award, or even a Padma Award — but not the Olympic medals. They're hidden in plain sight, right in the middle of the living room, casually placed on top of the coffee table. The only thing keeping them from being mistaken for coasters is the multi-coloured ribbons attached

to them.

"My medals are always on the teapoy. A lot of people come here who want to see and touch them. We don't have the right to shove them away in a showcase and say they can't be touched. So, they're right here. When a child comes and holds these medals, they should feel inspired to earn one of their own.

"When we go to temples, praying to an idol feels like a big deal — a marvel, a miracle. But these medals aren't like that. They're real. People touching them should realise that this is something they can work toward and achieve."

"Out of 100 people who touch the